

The Bookshop on Columbus

31 year old Theodore Hale strutted down Columbus Avenue, business cards in hand. Theodore was heading to an old bookshop in search of a novel to read during the upcoming Christmas holiday. He was a short, wide man wearing a navy blue headpiece, green mittens, and a black trench coat to keep warm from the opaque flakes dancing as they fell—faster with each waltz. The bustling city was overflowing with tourists during the holiday season. Waves of people, tall and round and brown and black and white were fighting to get a glimpse at the city or maybe even just to escape the crowd on their seemingly arduous voyage home from their office. Theodore, though he would rather not interact with the out-of-towners, saw them as business opportunities. He surveyed the crowd looking for people who may be interested in his work and what he could possibly sell to them. A pair of teenage girls met shoulders with Theodore, causing him to drop some of his business cards which quickly got stomped over.

“I’m so sorry sir!” one girl said, still giggling.

“It’s alright, apology accepted, but only if you take a business card,” snickered Theodore with an “obvious” tone of sarcasm in his voice.

She took the business card as they exchanged hopes that one another would have a good holiday and went their separate ways.

Theodore was always in search of the latest pieces of literature so that he could seem relatable and bright to his clients. He opened the rusting wrought iron gate and descended cautiously down the icy steps. He stood on the childish doormat at the door peering inside the Bluebird bookshop only to see an assortment of reds, yellows, and browns through the obscure glass. Theodore pushed the door open to the little tinkle of a bell, indicating a new customer was

in the store. The honking of horns and yelling disappeared once the door shut; it was like he was teleported from a bustling city to a small town in England. The murky light that shined through the clouds disappeared and was replaced with a welcoming golden glow that laid upon his face. On the tip of his nose brushed a musty waft of air filled with the breath of aged books that have lived nestled upon the shelves for decades and the breeze of a cool lake following an early winter rainstorm. The echo of small feet shuffling against the hardwood floors slowly approached him.

“Hello! Welcome to the Bluebird bookshop, how can I assist you today?” a plump, elderly woman questioned.

“Good evening Miss...”. Henry glanced down at the woman’s name card that was stuck onto her coral cardigan. The sticker had “Mary-Beth Barlowe” scribbled in plain black sharpie.

“... Barlowe. My name is Mr. Hale; I’m just here to look around for some scholarly books to read over the holiday. I run my very own business you see and it's going very well. Here’s my business card if you’re interested. I own a mattress department store,” he positively responded, holding a business card out to her.

“That's lovely sir, please let me know if you have trouble finding anything,” Miss. Barlowe responded while reluctantly taking the card from him. Miss. Barlowe was not used to exchanges like this with a customer randomly babbling on about their personal life.

Theodore left the small check out area at the front of the store and jumped down the two steps that lead to the sunken room where all of the books were asleep. He began his shopping wandering through the aisles and glancing at the books to his right and his left, stopping to admire the ambience. Both sides of the store had antique bookshelves covering the moss green walls. The floor was draped in a royal blue and beige Persian rug, with circular tables placed in the middle of the room. The tables were overflowing with books, maps, and lamps (Theodore

believed this was extremely unprofessional as it looked like he was in someone's personal office, not a book shop). The compact store had lights built in at the top of the shelves to illuminate the paintings resting on the wall, along with lamps built into the walls next to the hanging portraits.

In one of the dark aisles further into the shop and away from Theodore's line of vision, a lanky old man was observing thick aged books. He wore a white turtleneck on top of grey tailored pants with a black beret. Theodore lingered in nearby sections occasionally glancing over at the old man from the corner of his eye. For over half an hour the man never left the classical section of the shop and it aggravated Theodore till he could bear it no longer. He was extremely puzzled by the man's lack of movement. How could he be so fixated on such a topic? He confidently approached the man and introduced himself.

"Good evening sir." Not lifting his head from the book he was reading, he responded with a simple hello in a heavy Irish accent.

"Don't you just love the good old classics, especially during the holiday season?"

"Yes, I do enjoy older pieces of literature, though all year around."

Theodore takes a pause while inconspicuously glancing at the odd man every few seconds. He was either oblivious to the staring or chose not to care.

"Theodore Hale sir,"

"Finbarr Langston."

"Do you have a nickname?"

"My friends call me Finn on occasion,"

"Oh well then, what brings you here Finn?"

"I said my friends call me that," he paused. "We are not friends."

"I'm so sorry to disrespect you like that, Mr. Finbarr."

“It’s Mr. Langston to you boyo.”

Theodore was astounded that anyone would be so rude to his face, but Mr. Langston didn’t seem to care in the slightest. It took Theodore a few seconds to return to the conversation. Clearing his throat he continued making small talk.

“So ... where are you from?”

“West 81st and 7th. Manhattan.”

“But you don’t sound like a New Yorker?”

“ Why don’t you crack on an’ let me continue on with my day.”

“Well you see sir, I was just shopping around looking for Christmas presents for my family when I decided to come in here to buy a few novels to read over the holidays. When I came down here and saw you fixated on the classics, I wanted to ask you what you find so interesting about the old books?”

“Are you really judging me for reading old books?”

“No no nothing of the sort sir just curious you know. I mean in my opinion newly published books make you seem more... relatable?”

“I don’t read to please other people.”

Mr. Langston placed the book back in its home and turned to face the bookshelf on the neighboring wall. To those around him, he seemed as though he was admiring the old collection of James Joyce classics, but to Theodore it was a mystery needing to be solved. Mr. Langston took a deep breath at the dust bunnies before him, contemplating how to shoo away his unwanted guest. He was aware of Theodore’s subtle footsteps approaching the spot next to where he stood before they stopped and the stubby man appeared beside him. Observing the new wall of books he had yet to discover, Mr. Langston pulled *The Dead* by James Joyce off the shelf. He had

studied the novelist's more famous pieces such as *Ulysses* and *The Portrait of the Artist as a Young Man* during his time in Edinburgh where he was visiting the Central Library. When he pulled the novel off the shelf, a cloud of dust flew right into Theodore's face. Coughing and dusting off his coat, his annoying mouth opened to say something that was probably going to be irrelevant or stupid, if you asked Mr. Langston.

"Achoo, achoo! I'm allergic to ... achoo, dust. I'm going to die!" Theodore said in between sneezes.

"You'll be fine, it's just a wee bit of dust,"

Theodore cleared his throat and was off again rambling on and on to Mr. Langston: "Why don't you read modern books?" or "Have you read *A Beautiful Mind* by Sylvia Nassar? It's an amazing biography." Mr. Langston gave off short, unenthusiastic answers to Theodore's unending questions.

"I'm starting to think you haven't read a single book published after 1999," Theodore asked dumbfounded as to how someone could have missed so many great pieces of modern writing.

"I have not,"

"Why!"

"How do you tell someone to shut up without being rude?"

"Well it depends, who are you telling to shut up?"

"You."

"Mr. Langston, come on! Think about all the novels, poems, and stories you're missing out on,"

"I'm happy as I am."

Theodore was astounded that anyone could be so... stubborn.

In the summer he had run into a middle- aged couple who were Japanese tourists who were in New York via a home swap program. He managed to grab their attention while they were shopping in SoHo with the promise of a one-of-a-kind mattress that would stay cool during the sweltering summer nights. The pair fell in love with the snug bed and its imprinted red designs. It was a mattress imported from Italy and took six whole months to ship into Theodore's shop in Chelsea. Theodore had bought it for \$550.00, but was planning on selling it for at least \$1,200. When he mentioned the price, the man and Theodore almost immediately engaged in a back and forth rally over prices.

"It's for twelve hundred USD,"

"No, eight-hundred."

"Not happening, eleven hundred."

"Nine hundred,"

Theodore would not tolerate price negotiations, so he pulled out his fake sob scenario about how he needed the money and they settled for 1,000 dollars.

He shifted in his spot a little with the hardwood floors creaking beneath him. The wind was picking up outside, and Theodore was stumped in an attempt to get this old man to read a newer book at the Bluebird bookshop in the Big Apple. He gazed up at the windows above the bookcases to see the wind thrashing the small milky flakes against the screen. Clearing his throat, he attempted once more to get Mr. Finbar Langston from Londonderry, Ireland to read a book of his choice, but before he could open his mouth, a question escaped Mr. Langston's.

"Why are you so obsessed with modern literature? Honestly, it's brutal having to deal with you,"

“I’m not sure what you mean, sir,” Theodore responded questionably.

“What’s with you and your fixation with me reading a book of *your* choice aye?”

“I just... wouldn’t want people to find you unlikable, you know? ...or pick on you... because people can be brutal.”

“I’ve been on this earth for 67 years and set foot in this city over a decade ago, and you don’t think I know how the outside world is?”

“No, no, no, nothing like that...it’s just that with reading new books you’ll always have something to talk to someone about,”

“But your books are just one time period; you’ve never read the classics. Everyone knows about the classics.”

“Such as?”

“*Little Women* by Louisa May Alcott or Jane Austen’s *Pride and Prejudice*,”

“That is a good point...”

“Books like those get films made for every generation.”

Theodore hated to admit it, but old Mr. Langston was right. *Little Women* had been adapted by the movie industry and turned into a movie three times, once in 1933, 1949, and in 1994. *Pride and Prejudice* had been adapted and has had multiple spin-offs, with the first adaptation in 1895. Theodore remembered watching it for the first time when he visited his grandmother when he was little.

“Alright Mr. Langston, I have a proposition for you.”

For the first time since their conversation began, Mr. Langston lowered *The Dead* to look at Theodore in his eyes. He slid the novel back on the shelf and pivoted in his spot to face Theodore

“Go on,”

“We both have different reading types, but we both somewhat agree that all literature has value, regardless of when it’s written,”

“Yes...”

“So I propose this, I will read any book of your choice if you read a more recently published book.”

Mr. Langston looked down at the floor considering the idea. Finally, he gave in. Finbar handed Theodore a copy of *The Great Gatsby* by F. Scott Fitzgerald. In return, Theodore found a copy of *A Little Life* by Hanya Yanagihara. In silence, the pair walked up to the checkout area where Ms. Barlowe was fast asleep. Mr. Langston dropped his thick, 800 page, novel on the ground, which startled her awake. She quickly apologized and helped both of them check out. Mr. Langston and Theodore walked up the stairs and onto busy Columbus Avenue.

“Nice to meet you, Mr. Langston.”

“Same with you,”

The pair both walked opposite ways, off to enjoy the holidays.

Mr. Langston walked further and further away from The Bluebird Bookshop, smiling to himself in satisfied disbelief. He was pleasantly surprised that a kid could convince him to do something he never wished to.

